Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: November 9, 2026	**Entry:** 1
Description	A small U.S. health care clinic's operations were severely disrupted by a ransomware attack. It started with a phishing email, then encrypted the organization's files and demanded a ransom for the decryption key.
Tool(s) used	None

The 5 W's	The 5 W's of the incident:
	● **Who** caused the incident?
	  ● An organized group of unethical hackers, known to target the health care and transportation industries, sent the phishing emails. Their true identities are unknown.
	● **What** happened?
	  ● Targeted phishing emails with a malicious attachment were sent to several employees. Once an attachment was downloaded, it installed malware that gave the attackers access to the network. They then deployed ransomware that encrypted critical files, including patient records, and left a ransom note demanding payment for the decryption key.

	● **When** did the incident occur?
	  ● The incident happened on a Tuesday at about 9:00 a.m., when employees reported they couldn't access their files and saw a ransom note on their screens.
	● **Where** did the incident happen?
	  ● At a small U.S. health care clinic that provides primary-care services. The attack hit employees' computers and the company network, which shut down business operations.
	● **Why** did the incident happen?
	  ● The attackers got into the network with targeted phishing emails sent to several employees. The clinic likely had weak defenses against phishing, such as limited email filtering for malicious attachments or limited employee awareness training, which let the malware in. The attackers' goal was money: ransomware groups target health care because losing access to patient data puts heavy pressure on a clinic to pay.

Additional notes	Does the clinic train employees to spot phishing emails? Better awareness training and email filtering for malicious attachments could help prevent a repeat. Should the clinic pay the ransom, given there's no guarantee the attackers will hand over the decryption key?